Lesson 48: Style, Tone and Word Choice

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 6.9 Writing with Style; 6.10 Reading for and Writing with Tone; 6.11 Choosing Effective Words; and from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 6.3 Word Choice.

In this lesson

You will learn what a writer's style is and work on two of its three parts: tone and word choice. You will compare a magazine article with a research article, judge a student's tone and word choice, and practise connotation, formal vocabulary, fresh and specific language, and antonyms. These skills make your university essays sound serious, precise and consistent.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Describe the tone of a text with precise adjectives and judge whether it fits the context, purpose and audience.
- Keep an appropriate and consistent tone in academic writing.
- Use a dictionary and a thesaurus to choose words with the right denotation and connotation.
- Replace slang, clichés, overly general words and weak "to be" verbs with precise, formal language.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
style	the choices a writer makes to engage the reader and fit the context, purpose, content and audience	Tone, word choice and sentence variety are strategies for writing with style.
tone	the attitude a writer shows toward the subject (also called "voice")	The research article has a formal, factual tone.
jarring	sudden and unpleasant; used for a break in tone	a sarcastic comment in a professional essay
denotation	the dictionary definition of a word	Scrawny, skinny and lean have similar denotations.
connotation	the emotional or cultural meaning of a word: positive, negative or neutral	Scrawny has a negative connotation.
slang	informal, nonstandard words that change with fashion	"I still bombed" (= I still failed)

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
cliché	an expression that has lost its effect through overuse	"...makes my blood boil"
overly general word	a word that gives the reader no clear picture	"My new puppy is cute."
synonym	a word with the same, or almost the same, meaning	easy / simple; city / metropolis
antonym	a word with the opposite meaning	abundant / scarce; conceal / reveal
thesaurus	a reference that lists synonyms and antonyms	Look for alternatives in a thesaurus.
etymology	the history of a word	myth: from Greek mythos, "a fable"

Rules and explanations

Style: three strategies

A writer's style is what sets their writing apart. The book gives three strategies:

1. intentionally creating an appropriate **tone**;
2. choosing **words** that illustrate and enliven your writing;
3. using a **variety of sentence types** (Lesson 49).

Tone

Tone is the attitude your words show toward your subject. The photo caption "Way cool! This used to be a liquor store in my neighborhood. Now it's a great little grocery!" has a casual, enthusiastic tone: perfect for someone walking past the store, wrong in a statistical report.

Tones that usually fit academic writing	Tones that usually do not
formal, serious, professional; dry, factual, direct; incisive, critical, thoughtful; cautious	informal, casual, conversational, breezy; humorous, witty; sarcastic, flippant; angry, bitter, cynical

When you revise, ask:

- **What is your tone?** Is it how you intend to sound?
- **Is it appropriate** for the context, purpose and audience?
- **Is it consistent?** Look for jarring breaks: slang, a very informal phrase or a sarcastic comment in an otherwise professional text.

Word choice for style

- Replace "to be" verbs (is, was, were) with more action-packed verbs where you can.
- Replace vague words such as "things", "very" and "many" with precise terms.
- If you repeat a word or phrase too much, find alternatives in a thesaurus, then check them in a dictionary.

Dictionary and thesaurus

A dictionary gives a word's spelling, pronunciation, part of speech, definition, synonyms and etymology (see the entry for **myth** in your material). A thesaurus lists synonyms and antonyms: **precocious**: uncommonly smart, mature, advanced, smart, bright, brilliant, gifted, quick, clever, apt. Ant. slow, backward, stupid.

Denotation and connotation

Scrawny, **skinny** and **lean** all mean "very thin", but their connotations differ:

- "Although he was a premature baby and a **scrawny** child, Martin has developed into a strong man." (negative: weakness)
- "**Skinny** jeans have become very fashionable in the past couple of years." (positive: fashion)
- "My brother has a **lean** figure, whereas I have a more muscular build." (neutral)

Language to avoid in academic writing

Problem	Book's example	Better
Slang (fine between friends, in texts and e-mails)	"I still bombed."	I still failed.
Cliché (overused, so unoriginal)	...he always says something that makes my **blood boil**.	...makes me want to go to the gym and punch the bag for a few hours.
Overly general words	My teacher told us that plagiarism is bad.	My teacher, Ms. Atwater, created a presentation detailing exactly how plagiarism is illegal and unethical.

Synonyms and antonyms

- Synonyms are rarely fully interchangeable: **insipid** means nearly the same as **boring** but sounds more scholarly, perhaps pretentious.
- Learning antonyms in pairs (absence / presence, borrow / lend, permanent / temporary) sharpens your sense of language. Study the table of common antonyms in your material.

> **In psychology:** in research writing (APA style), "significant" usually means "statistically significant", as in the Chen et al. excerpt. When you only mean "important" or "large", use those words.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic often adds emphasis by repeating an idea with two near-synonyms or a colourful fixed expression. In English academic writing this sounds overstated: choose one precise word. - Translated proverbs and set phrases usually become clichés in English. Say the idea plainly.

Practice

Exercise 1. Comparing tone. Read the two excerpts under "Comparing tone" in the lesson material: Field's "Eye On The Prize" (Forbes magazine) and Chen et al.'s "Food Environments and Obesity" (a research article).

1. How would you describe the tone of each excerpt?
2. Which is more formal? Which is more conversational?
3. Which words and phrases demonstrate the tone of each?

Exercise 2. Tone in a student essay. Read the fourth paragraph of Amanda's essay ("However, many residents of West Oakland believe...").

1. How would you describe her tone?
2. Find two places that break the academic tone, and revise them.

Exercise 3. Connotations. In each group, which word is positive, which negative and which neutral?

1. curious, nosy, interested
2. lazy, relaxed, slow
3. courageous, foolhardy, assured
4. new, newfangled, modern
5. mansion, shack, residence
6. spinster, unmarried woman, career woman
7. giggle, laugh, cackle
8. boring, routine, prosaic
9. noted, notorious, famous
10. assertive, confident, pushy

Exercise 4. Slang. In the paragraph under "Avoiding Slang" ("I felt like such an airhead..."), replace each slang expression with formal language: airhead; Man,; klutz; On top of that; stressed out; 24/7; bombed; going off about; boo; not to sweat it; whiz; speech giving stuff; guts.

Exercise 5. Clichés. Revise the ten sentences under "Avoiding Clichés" in the lesson material ("She is writing a memoir..." to "Jordan was dressed to the nines that night."). Replace each cliché with a fresh, original description.

Exercise 6. Overly general words. Revise the ten sentences under "Avoiding Overly General Words" ("Adyam got into her car and drove off." to "I enjoyed my Mexican meal.") with precise, attractive language.

Exercise 7. Antonyms. Do the exercise under "Antonyms" (ten sentences, "The pilot who landed the plane was a coward..."). In each sentence one word makes it illogical; it is underlined in the book, but the underlining is lost in your material. Find the word and replace it with an antonym.

Exercise 8. Word choice in a student essay. Read the fifth paragraph of Amanda's essay ("Food hubs supply fresh vegetables and fruits…").

1. Where is her word choice especially effective?
2. Find repeated words and weak verbs, and revise two sentences.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my formal rewrite of the 'airhead' paragraph from the lesson material: [paste]. Is any slang left? Is my tone consistent?"
- "Give me ten casual sentences about student life. I will rewrite each in an academic tone; tell me which words still sound informal."
- "Check my sentences for the synonym pairs in the lesson material (leave / abandon, poor / destitute…). Does each one show the specific meaning?"
- "Let's discuss: Is the Forbes article less useful than the research article because its tone is informal? When could a psychology student use each as a source?"

Read aloud

Read sentences 1 and 2 with lively, conversational intonation and the others slowly and evenly.

1. Way cool! This used to be a liquor store in my neighborhood.
2. We pretty quickly realized we hadn't a clue how to do that.
3. A number of recent studies have uncovered significant as·so·ci·A·tions between the neighborhood food environment and health outcomes.
4. Other studies, however, have found no such sta·TIS·ti·cal·ly significant relationships.
5. A con·no·TA·tion is the emotional or cultural meaning attached to a word.

Writing task

Part A (the book's Writing Application). In 100-150 words, describe your favourite dish. Use a thesaurus and as many synonyms as you can, including words you have never used before.

Part B (Apply this). Take a paragraph of 150-250 words from one of your essays in this course, or write a new academic paragraph on a psychology topic (how the food environment affects what people eat, from the PSYC 110 guest lecture on food, or how sleep affects memory). Revise it for tone and word choice; keep both versions.

Self-editing checklist:

- Is my tone formal, serious and consistent, with no slang, exclamations or sarcasm?
- Does it fit my purpose and audience?
- Have I replaced "to be" verbs with action verbs where possible?
- Have I replaced vague words ("things", "very", "many") with precise terms?
- Have I removed clichés and overly general words?

- Does every word have the connotation I intend?
- Have I avoided repeating words, and checked each new synonym in a dictionary?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer)

1. Field: informal, conversational, light, enthusiastic. Chen et al.: formal, serious, dry, factual, cautious.
2. Chen et al. is more formal; Field is more conversational.
3. Field: "Talk about commitment to a mission"; "for a really long time"; the openers "The objective:" and "Plus"; the writer's comment "sensibly"; the casual quotation "We pretty quickly realized..."; the idiom "get their feet wet". Chen et al.: technical terms ("health outcomes", "statistically significant relationships"); careful comparisons ("most common... less common... rarer still"); references to other studies; no idioms or personal comments.

Exercise 2 (example answer)

1. Mostly formal, serious and factual: transitions (However, Thus), evidence and a cited quotation from Sam Bloch.
2. "Admittedly, it is true." is vague and sounds like speech: "Admittedly, this belief is correct." "...and that is convenient for them" repeats "convenient": "They think this because many corner liquor stores are nearby." Also possible: "don't" becomes "do not"; "Research on Google Maps" becomes "A search on Google Maps".

Exercise 3 (positive / negative / neutral)

1. curious / nosy / interested (interested as positive and curious as neutral is also acceptable)
2. relaxed / lazy / slow
3. courageous / foolhardy / assured (assured can also be positive)
4. modern / newfangled / new (new as positive and modern as neutral is also acceptable)
5. mansion / shack / residence
6. career woman / spinster / unmarried woman
7. giggle / cackle / laugh
8. no clearly positive word / boring, and prosaic (a formal word for "dull, ordinary") / routine (prosaic as neutral, meaning "ordinary, matter-of-fact", is also acceptable)
9. famous or noted / notorious (famous for something bad) / the other of the two
10. confident / pushy / assertive (assertive is often positive, too)

Exercise 4 (example answers) airhead: foolish; Man,: delete it; klutz: clumsy; On top of that: In addition; stressed out: anxious; 24/7: constantly; bombed: failed, performed poorly; going off about: talking at length about; boo: show their disapproval; not to sweat it: not to worry; whiz: skilled speaker; speech giving stuff: public speaking; guts: courage.

Exercise 5 (example answers)

1. She is writing a memoir in which she will reveal the secrets her family has hidden for thirty years.

2. Beth had resented Allen since he took credit for her project, and she planned to confront him at the party.
3. Mr. Nguyen had tried every strategy he knew with the rowdy class of seventh graders and was ready to give up.
4. Joel was fired for one reason: he missed too many days of work.
5. Sometimes one paycheck does not cover rent, food and bills.
6. After studying until dawn, I cannot hold a single thought in my head.
7. Maria left the dishes in the sink all week to show Jose how it feels to come home to someone else's mess.
8. ...Janice exclaimed, "I can't believe it is already dark. We have been here for six hours!"
9. Jeremy stammered and stared at the floor after the interviewer asked him where he saw himself in five years.
10. Jordan wore a tailored black suit, polished shoes and a silk tie that night.

Exercise 6 (example answers)

1. Adyam slid into her old red Toyota and sped out of the parking lot.
2. I would like to travel to outer space to see the curve of the Earth and float without gravity.
3. Drashty came home exhausted and silent after her manager criticized her report in front of the whole team.
4. Mohamed's essay fascinated me because it showed how easily false memories can form.
5. The old beagle limped slowly up the steep street.
6. The coal miners trudged home, faces black with dust, after a twelve-hour shift.
7. The tropical fish flash orange, yellow and electric blue as they dart through the coral.
8. Sweat pours down my face and soaks my shirt after a five-mile run.
9. The goalie dived and pushed the shot around the post with her fingertips.
10. I enjoyed the spicy chicken enchiladas with green salsa.

Exercise 7

1. coward: hero
2. dull: interesting, fascinating
3. impolite: polite
4. ignorance: knowledge, wisdom
5. compulsory: optional
6. virtues: vices
7. bold: timid, meek, shy
8. freedom: captivity
9. gloomy: hopeful, optimistic
10. guest: host (or "attended to": ignored)

Exercise 8 (example answer)

1. Specific names ("food hubs", "Mandela Marketplace", "City Slicker Farms"), strong verbs ("supply", "obtain") and a well-chosen quotation from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.
2. "food" appears six times (not counting the citation), "residents" three times and "community garden(s)" four times (once in the quotation). "Another resource that helps residents to access healthy food is learning how to grow vegetables and fruits in community gardens." becomes "Residents can also learn to grow their own produce in community gardens." "Community gardens provide places that allow people to plant food for themselves. One famous community garden is known as City Slicker Farms." becomes "In community gardens, people grow food for themselves; City Slicker Farms is a well-known example."

My notes